

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

5 August 2001

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

The Universal House of Justice has asked us to provide you with the results of an assessment of the present state and needs of the international funds of the Faith which it has conducted following completion of the projects on Mount Carmel.

There can be no doubt that this accomplishment, followed by the spectacular success of the ceremony marking the official opening to the public of the Terraces of the Shrine of the Báb, has infused the community of the Greatest Name throughout the world with fresh vigour and confidence as it embarks upon the Five Year Plan and seeks to advance the process of entry by troops.

Through the sacrificial contributions of the believers from all parts of the planet, sufficient funds were provided to meet the needs of this historic enterprise and permit the construction to proceed unimpeded to its conclusion. The House of Justice has decided to close the Arc Projects Fund forthwith, with confidence that the funds remaining in it will suffice to meet the outstanding expenses of the construction and the purchase of some required properties on the perimeter of the Terraces.

It is now apparent that the needs of the Bahá'í International Fund have increased substantially as a consequence of a number of recent developments, including the following:

The sharp increase in the tempo of Bahá'í activity throughout the world with the launch of the Five Year Plan has created a pressing need for resources to meet the new opportunities now emerging to promote growth and to influence society.

Adequate resources must be allocated for the maintenance of the Terraces and edifices of the Arc, including the preservation of the high standard of the gardens and lawns, the upkeep of the structures and ornaments, and the provision of appropriate security measures.

Guides must be provided for the rising number of visitors to the Terraces, now estimated to be 35,000 members of the public each week, including those who are conducted on tours in groups of 60 at a time during the daylight hours, 7 days a week.

Greater attention must be given without delay to the preservation of the precious documents and objects associated with the ministries of the Central Figures of the Faith and of Shoghi Effendi so that deterioration of these irreplaceable items is arrested.

These increased demands have arisen at a time when economic conditions in the world and other factors have caused a significant reduction in the level of income to the Bahá'í International Fund. The House of Justice is confident that the spirit of sacrifice demonstrated by the believers in their support of the Arc Projects Fund will animate their response to the pressing needs of the Bahá'í International Fund in the years immediately ahead.

We have been asked to assure you of the prayers of the House of Justice in the Holy Shrines for your guidance as you deliberate on means by which the flow of the resources necessary to meet the international obligations of the Cause can be augmented.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]